Name the feeling

Name it to tame it

ONE TINY TRY FOR TODAY

Tonight, you each name one feeling: hurt, angry, disappointed, or something else.

WHAT SCIENCE SAYS

In studies with adults, naming feelings sometimes helped people feel less upset. We need stronger tests with children aged 8 to 13.

NAME

HOW TO REMEMBER IT

Name it to tame it

Touch your chest together. Say the feeling's name.

WHAT I CAN DO

When I notice _____,

I _____.

Backup: Breathe out slowly

WHERE IT CAME FROM

Torre and Lieberman, UCLA, 2018. Search: affect labeling review.

Chapter 1: The Next Game

The teams were full.

Pip wanted to play.

He walked to the bench.

At recess, his face felt hot. His hands were tight. The soccer game went on without him.

That evening, Pip and Dad sat on the sofa, calm enough to read together. Dad held a comic open on his lap.

“I wanted to play,” Pip said.

Dad left the page where it was. “You wanted to be part of the game.”

Pip nodded. Dad listened while he told the whole thing.

“It was just bad,” Pip said.

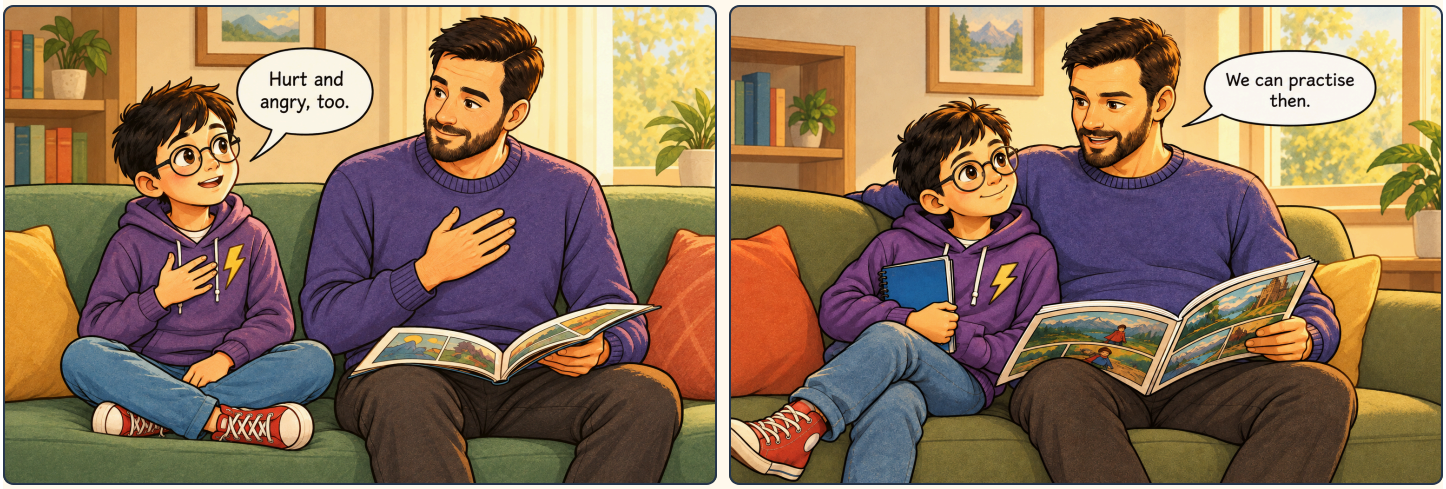
“Want to find a word that fits?” Dad asked. “Maybe left out? You can tell me if I’m wrong.”

“Left out fits,” Pip said. “I was sitting there while the game went on.”

“I felt left out today, too,” Dad said. “Someone talked over me at work. I’m learning to name my feelings, just like you.”

Pip rested a hand on his chest. Dad put his free hand on his own chest.

Chapter 1: The Next Game



“Hurt and angry, too,” Pip said.

“Both at once,” Dad said. “Name it to tame it. Those words help me understand what you need.”

“I’m still angry.”

“You can be angry and sit close to me.”

Pip leaned against Dad. The comic stayed open between them.

After a while, Dad asked, “Want to try saying, ‘Can I join the next game?’”

“Tomorrow before school?”

“We can practise then.”

“What if they still say no?”

“That could happen. You could ask someone else to play. If you keep getting left out, tell a teacher you like, just as you told me tonight.”

“You’ll listen tomorrow, too?”

“Tomorrow, too.”

Pip pointed to the comic. “Now the funny bit.”

Dad read it in his silliest voice. Pip laughed against his shoulder.

Recess still hurt. But Pip had words for the feeling, a next step to try, and Dad beside him.

TRY IT

The page that matters

FEEL FIRST, FOR DAD

Being left out hurt. You wanted to play.

You can still feel angry while we talk.

MY ONE MOVE

When I notice _____ ,

I _____ .

Another way to try: Try three slow breaths out. Stop if your head feels funny.

TINY TRY, PICK ONE

1. Think of a small bother. Name the feeling that fits. Mad, sad or another word is okay.
2. Choose two feeling words if both fit. Say them together.
3. Think of another small moment. Name the feeling that fits. Tell each other why that word fits.

TALK

What did it feel like right before?

What helped most, and how did you know?

Offer the two questions. The child may choose one or skip both. Ask a second only if the child wants to keep talking.

WHERE ELSE

Think of a place you might be tomorrow, away from a screen. What would you notice? Picture trying your move.

On the walk home from school with a grown-up.

This week I tried: _____ _____

CARDS + GROWN-UP GUIDE

DAD CARD

1. I noticed you looked left out. That makes sense.
2. Want me to listen, help you think of an idea, or give you some space?
3. Want to try “name the feeling” now, or later?
4. You did the move. What did you notice?

On another calm day, try to remember the idea together. Turn the card over for help. To make a paper card, cut around the outside and fold down the middle.

REMEMBER CARD, FRONT

Name the feeling

NAME

Think back. What did you first notice in your thoughts or body?

What is your move? Try to remember and show it. Then turn over and check.

Think of another time. Would this move fit? Would another way or some help fit better?

REMEMBER CARD, BACK

When to try it: When you say you feel bad but another word might fit.

Tonight, you each name one feeling: hurt, angry, disappointed, or something else.

My move: _____

Name it to tame it

☐ Remembered it ☐ Practised it

☐ Used it for real

GROWN-UP NOTES, FOR DAD

Try together: When you are both calm, ask: “What feeling fits?” Listen. Then choose one small thing to try together.

Name it to tame it: Use your familiar reminder when a new hard moment comes along.

What research says: In some studies with adults, naming feelings helped people feel less upset. That does not tell us whether this story helps children.

Read more: Sources and study details are in the app. Torre and Lieberman, 2018. DOI 10.1177/1754073917742706; PubMed 31246045